women, who rode on horseback, participated in mixed gatherings at banquets and feasts, and travelled with their husbands and sons, had now suddenly become opaque. This was noted in a history of the reign of Akbar's grandson, Shah Jahan, when it was written that 'ever since the reign of Akbar, it had been ordained that the names of the inmates of the seraglio should not be mentioned in public, but that they should be designated by some epithet derived either from the place of their birth or the city in which they might have first been regarded by the monarch with the eye of affection'. That there was a growing Mughal desire to circumscribe the harem within an ordered space as a reflection of the exalted charisma of the Padshah, which now removed the harem from the sight of ordinary people, is clear from Abu'l Fazl's writings. But there may also have been something the Rajput brides brought with them, along with their gods, dancing girls, and feasts, that made this process inevitable.

In the turbulent, fractious environment of Rajasthan, the clan structure of ruling families was the scaffolding upon which layers of loyalty were constructed. On the one hand there were the rulers, linked to their thikanedars and small jagirdars in an intricate web of blood and obligation called bhai-beta, or clan. A further unit of relationship and strength increasingly became the saga, the in-law family, who were also expected to provide warriors and fealty in times of strife. Marriages between two weaker clans could provide ballast against more formidable neighbours while clans could try to appease encroaching pretenders by offering daughters in marriage, thus securing bonds and alliances. As a result, polygamy became rampant in the ruling houses of Rajasthan, the women often inconsequential beyond their ability to produce brave sons to fight and die magnificently in their endless battles. In an extreme example, Rawat Durga Das of Deogarh married strong horse-riding women and then kept them in seclusion to breed sons who would, it was hoped, be as fearless as their mothers had once dreamed of being. In genealogies and chronicles, the Rajput women lost their names, their individuality now smooth as river stones, hidden behind the name of their fathers' clans. As Rajput kinship networks evolved through the centuries, regulating the place of these elite Rajput women and their chastity became deeply embedded in the honour of the clan; this also became an increasingly confounding problem for these polygamous households. Widow remarriage, also known as nata marriages, which did occur in earlier, more forgiving times, were now deemed